Chinese Practice Lesson 03 · Study Guide

Soochow University · 22 Oct 2026 · Vocabulary, grammar, and examples from today's class.

Grammar and usage

Today’s lesson focused on time expressions, the difference between 过 and 了, negation with 不 vs 没, yes/no question patterns, and a few weather / daily routine examples.

V + 过

Meaning: Shows that somebody has had the experience of doing something before.

Example: 他去过上海。 Tā qù guo Shànghǎi. / 你看过这个电影吗？ Nǐ kàn guo zhège diànyǐng ma?

Note: 过 talks about past experience. It does not mean the person is there now.

V + 了

Meaning: Shows completion or a new situation / change. It often implies the action has happened and the result is relevant now.

Example: 他去上海了。 Tā qù Shànghǎi le.

Note: In today’s contrast: 他去上海了 can imply he has gone there and is there now.

不 vs 没

Meaning: 不 is common for present / future / habitual negation; 没 is common for past / completed negation.

Example: 每天我不吃早饭。 / 昨天我没吃早饭。

Note: Do not translate them both simply as “not”; the time meaning matters.

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Grammar and usage

吗 / A-not-A

Meaning: Two common yes/no question patterns.

Example: 你是中国人吗？ = 你是不是中国人？ / 你吃包子吗？ = 你吃不吃包子？

Note: A-not-A repeats the verb or adjective with 不 in the middle.

有 + N / 有没有 + N

Meaning: Use 有 with nouns meaning “have / there is”. Negation is 没有, not 不有.

Example: 你有中国朋友吗？ = 你有没有中国朋友？ / A: 有。 A: 没有。

Note: Incorrect: 不有 ✗

今天晴，但是很冷。

Meaning: Simple weather sentence with adjective + contrast.

Example: 今天有太阳。 / 今天晴，但是很冷。 / 二十度，很凉。

Note: 很 often links the subject with an adjective and is not always strongly “very”.

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A visual map of time expressions from today's class.

TIME EXPRESSIONS

Earlier ← NOW → Later

Days

−2	−1	NOW	+1	+2
前天 qián tiān day before yesterday	昨天 zuó tiān yesterday	今天 jīn tiān today	明天 míng tiān tomorrow	后天 hòu tiān day after tomorrow

Years

−2	−1	NOW	+1	+2
前年 qián nián year before last	去年 qù nián last year	今年 jīn nián this year	明年 míng nián next year	后年 hòu nián year after next

Months

−2	−1	NOW	+1	+2
上上个月 shàng shàng ge yuè month before last	上个月 shàng ge yuè last month	这个月 zhè ge yuè this month	下个月 xià ge yuè next month	下下个月 xià xià ge yuè month after next

Weeks

−2	−1	NOW	+1	+2
上上个星期 shàng shàng ge xīngqī week before last	上个星期 shàng ge xīngqī last week	这个星期 zhè ge xīngqī this week	下个星期 xià ge xīngqī next week	下下个星期 xià xià ge xīngqī week after next

Daily rhythm

NOON				
早上 zǎo shang morning	上午 shàng wǔ late morning	中午 zhōng wǔ noon	下午 xià wǔ afternoon	晚上 wǎn shang evening

Build complete expressions, not isolated characters:

今天　今年　这个月　这个星期

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A visual map of time expressions from today’s class.

Build time expressions

Learn the repeating structure, not isolated characters.

Day structure

前天	昨天	今天	明天	后天
qián tiān	zuó tiān	jīn tiān	míng tiān	hòu tiān
2 before	previous	NOW	next	2 after

Year structure

前年	去年	今年	明年	后年
qián nián	qù nián	jīn nián	míng nián	hòu nián
2 before	previous	NOW	next	2 after

Month structure

上上个月	上个月	这个月	下个月	下下个月
shàng shàng ge yuè	shàng ge yuè	zhè ge yuè	xià ge yuè	xià xià ge yuè
2 before	previous	NOW	next	2 after

Week structure

上上个星期	上个星期	这个星期	下个星期	下下个星期
shàng shàng ge xīngqī	shàng ge xīngqī	zhè ge xīngqī	xià ge xīngqī	xià xià ge xīngqī
2 before	previous	NOW	next	2 after

Day and year expressions share a second character: day or year. The first character changes.
Month and week expressions combine direction + classifier + month or week.

The centre word identifies the present. Move left for the past and right for the future.

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A visual map of time expressions from today's class.

Daily rhythm · from morning to evening

Daily rhythm

NOON

早上	上午	中午	下午	晚上
zǎo shang	shàng wǔ	zhōng wǔ	xià wǔ	wǎn shang
morning	late morning	noon	afternoon	evening

Meals

早饭	午饭	晚饭
zǎo fàn	中饭	wǎn fàn
breakfast	wǔ fàn / zhōng fàn	**dinner**
	lunch	

Weather and temperature

太阳	晴	雨	凉
tài yáng	qíng	yǔ	liáng
sun	sunny	rain	cool

冷	度	零	两
lěng	dù	líng	liǎng
cold	degree	zero	two

Weather example

今天晴，但是很冷。

jīn tiān qíng, dàn shì hěn lěng.

It is sunny today, but very cold.

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Question and grammar words

Chinese	Pinyin	Meaning
有	yǒu	to have
没有	méi yǒu	not to have
不	bù	not (present / future / habitual)
没	méi	not (past / completed)
过	guo	experience marker
了	le	change / completion marker
吗	ma	question particle
中国人	zhōng guó rén	Chinese person
中国朋友	zhōng guó péng you	Chinese friend
女朋友	nǚ péng you	girlfriend
包子	bāo zi	baozi
电影	diàn yǐng	movie
上海	shàng hǎi	Shanghai
苏州	sū zhōu	Suzhou

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Sentence writing

他去过上海。
tā qù guo shàng hǎi.
He has been to Shanghai.

他现在在苏州。
tā xiàn zài zài sū zhōu.
He is in Suzhou now.

他去上海了。
tā qù shàng hǎi le.
He has gone to Shanghai.

他现在在上海。
tā xiàn zài zài shàng hǎi.
He is in Shanghai now.

你去过上海吗？
nǐ qù guo shàng hǎi ma?
Have you been to Shanghai?

你看过这个电影吗？
nǐ kàn guo zhè ge diàn yǐng ma?
Have you seen this movie?

你有中国朋友吗？
nǐ yǒu zhōng guó péng you ma?
Do you have Chinese friends?

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Sentence writing

你有没有中国朋友？
nǐ yǒu méi yǒu zhōng guó péng you?
Do you have Chinese friends?

你吃包子吗？
nǐ chī bāo zi ma?
Do you eat baozi?

你吃不吃包子？
nǐ chī bu chī bāo zi?
Do you eat baozi?

每天我不吃早饭。
měi tiān wǒ bù chī zǎo fàn.
Every day I do not eat breakfast.

昨天我没吃早饭。
zuó tiān wǒ méi chī zǎo fàn.
Yesterday I did not eat breakfast.

今天晴，但是很冷。
jīn tiān qíng, dàn shì hěn lěng.
Today it is sunny, but very cold.

今天有太阳。
jīn tiān yǒu tài yáng.
Today there is sun / it is sunny.

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Sentence writing

你们今天很早。

nǐ men jīn tiān hěn zǎo.

You are early today.